

ATTENTION IS NEW GOLD

How to make your brand and stories stand out. ↗

How to make your brand and stories stand out in the most distracted era in human history.

BRAND FUNDAMENTALS

THE TRUTH FRAMEWORK

CAMPAIGN DESIGN

BEHAVIOURAL SCIENCE

6 FIELD LESSONS

SETTING THE SCENE

Why Attention Matters More Than Ever

We are producing more content than at any point in human history ... and most of it is ignored. It's estimated the average person encounters between **4,000 and 10,000 brand messages a day**. People have become very selective & efficient at filtering out things that don't matter to them.

For a startup or scaleup, this creates a painful paradox: you need attention to grow, but the cost of earning it keeps rising while the window you have to earn it keeps shrinking.

ASK YOURSELF

When did I last stop scrolling because something genuinely grabbed me? What was it about that thing?

BRAND FUNDAMENTALS

The Cornerstones of Brand Value

A 'brand' can be summed up as **'What people say about you when you're not in the room'**. Before worrying about content or campaigns, the brand itself must earn trust. A strong brand makes a promise that is:



... and most importantly: **delivered consistently**. Each quality builds on the last. You can be valuable but not relevant (wrong audience). Relevant but not differentiated (forgettable). Differentiated but not trustworthy (hollow). Only when all four are present — and sustained — does a brand compound in value.

ASK YOURSELF

Which of the four cornerstones is my weakest right now? (That's your highest-leverage place to focus.)

STORY FRAMEWORK

What Every Good Story Has in Common: TRUTH

Run any piece of content through TRUTH before it goes out. If it fails more than two of the five, rework it. The **Tension test** is the one most founders consistently fail.

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS	ASK YOURSELF
T Topical	Tied to what matters right now ... in the world, your industry, or your audience's daily life. Timely stories travel further.	Is this connected to something people are thinking about today?
R Relevant	Speaks directly to your reader's real situation. Not about you ... about what they're trying to solve, achieve, or avoid.	Would my ideal customer think 'this is written for me'?
U Unusual	Contains something surprising or counterintuitive. Predictable stories are forgettable stories. ('Man bites dog.')	Is there something here that would make someone pause?
T Trouble/Tension	Every great story has a problem at its centre. Without tension, there's often little reason to keep reading.	What's broken, at stake, or unresolved in this story?
H Human(ity)	Feature real people, real stakes, real emotion. The more specific and human the story, the more universal its appeal. (Think: 'case study')	Who is the real person at the centre of this story?

PLACES TO START

In all these cases the more you have to **combine information with opinion**. Points of view are **much** better received than information alone.

CONTENT	WHAT TO COVER	WHEN TO SHARE IT
Industry-related	Knowledge your organisation shares about news and trends (to add insight and clarity to what's going on).	With cold audiences who don't know you yet
Organisational	Take a strong point of view on how you conduct business, or how you treat employees or other stakeholders.	When audiences are aware of you (warm) and you want to build trust
Product	Employ your product-related expertise in the context of helping people solve their real-world problems.	With warm audiences ready to consider your solution

CAMPAIGN DESIGN

The 7 Questions Behind Every Effective Campaign

Whether it's a product launch or content series, every campaign worth running answers these questions in order. Skip one and the whole thing gets wobbly.

- 1 What are our goals?**
Business goals aligned with marketing & comms objectives
- 2 Who are we talking to?**
Primary, secondary & eavesdroppers. Where are they in their journey? (Don't ask people to marry you on the first date.)
- 3 What do audiences care about?**
What matters to them? Where do our goals and theirs overlap? (Many founders skip this.)
- 4 What story will we tell and how?**
Interesting narratives. Key messages. Evidence & data. How will it be cut for different channels?
- 5 When do we tell our stories?**
Proactive & reactive opportunities.
- 6 Where do we tell our stories?**
Where is the audience? What are their 'spheres of influence' across paid, earned & owned channels?
- 7 How did our content perform?**
Measure, analyse, optimise

BEHAVIOURAL SCIENCE

8 Principles Of Behavioural Science That Win Customers

Customers don't make rational decisions. They think they do. But they don't. They make fast, intuitive ones ... and then rationalise them afterwards. Understanding the cognitive shortcuts that drive behaviour is one of the highest-leverage things a founder can learn.

01

Social Proof

When uncertain, people look to what others are doing. Numbers and named examples carry more weight than any self-claim.

Lead with specific customer numbers and verbatim quotes. 'Over 3,000 teams use us' beats 'trusted by thousands'.

02

Loss Aversion

Losses feel roughly twice as powerful as equivalent gains. People are more motivated to avoid losing than to acquire something new.

Reframe around what they're losing by not acting: time, revenue, competitive advantage. 'Don't lose another deal' often outperforms 'close more deals'.

03

Authority Bias

People defer to perceived experts and credible sources, often without questioning the underlying evidence.

Earn and display authority signals: press coverage, awards, advisors, speaking slots. One credible mention changes how people assess everything else.

04

Reciprocity

When someone gives us something, we feel a deep obligation to give something back. One of the most universal human instincts.

Give genuine value before asking for anything (e.g. tools, research, templates, introductions). The gift must feel unconditional to work.

05

Default Effect

People have a powerful tendency to stick with whatever option requires no active choice. Changing defaults is one of the highest-leverage design moves.

Make the behaviour you want the path of least resistance. Pre-select your recommended plan. Make signing up easier than not signing up.

06

Cognitive Fluency

The easier something is to understand, the more trustworthy and credible it feels. Complexity signals risk. Clarity signals competence.

Rewrite your homepage until a 12-year-old could understand what you do and why it matters. Simplify pricing.

07

Anchoring

The first number someone encounters sets a reference point that shapes all subsequent judgements, even when arbitrary.

Always show your highest pricing tier first. Anchor the cost of the problem before presenting your solution's price. Name your number first.

08

Peak-End Rule

People judge experiences by how they felt at the peak and at the end – not the average across the whole experience.

Obsess over onboarding and the renewal/referral moment. A rocky middle is forgivable if the peak and ending are exceptional.

THE MOST POWERFUL COMBINATION

Combine **loss aversion + social proof + reciprocity** in a single message: show what others are gaining that your prospect is currently missing, and give them something useful for free before you ask for anything.

LESSONS THAT ACTUALLY MOVE THE NEEDLE

Lessons 01–03

LESSON 01

You Don't Have an Attention Problem, You Have a Relevance Problem

Most founders think they're losing the battle for attention because they lack budget, reach, or followers. Usually the real issue is simpler: **what they're saying isn't specific enough to matter to anyone in particular**. Generic content slides straight past people. Specific, honest, particular content — the kind that makes someone think 'this is written for me' — stops them cold.

TAKEAWAY

Before asking 'how do we get more reach?', ask 'is what we're saying specific enough to resonate deeply with anyone?' The goal is to be unmissable to the right 1,000 people, not invisible to the wrong million.

LESSON 02

The Founder Voice Is an Unfair Advantage ... If You Actually Use It

Institutional brand content from a startup is almost always weaker than content from the founder. People follow people, not logos. Your perspective, your reasoning, your mistakes, your bets on the future — none of that can be replicated by a competitor, **because it's uniquely yours**. The founders who build real attention don't post marketing. They share what they're genuinely thinking about. Points of view are much better received than information alone.

TAKEAWAY

The most powerful thing you can do for your brand costs nothing except courage: write in your actual voice about things you actually believe. Disagree with received wisdom. Safe content is invisible content.

LESSON 03

Story Structure Is a Skill, Not a Gift

The founders who communicate well aren't necessarily more interesting — they've learned how to structure what they say. Use this framework: **Tension** (something broken or counterintuitive) → **Insight** (what you've learned) → **Implication** (what it means for how they should act).

'Most people think X, but I've come to believe Y, which means Z.'

TAKEAWAY

Before you write anything, complete: 'Most people think X, but I've come to believe Y, which means Z.' If you can't complete that sentence, you don't have a story yet (you have a topic).

LESSONS THAT ACTUALLY MOVE THE NEEDLE

Lessons 04–06

LESSON 04

Consistency Beats Virality

Everyone wants the viral moment. But the brands and founders with durable attention aren't the ones who went viral. They're the ones who showed up reliably over time until showing up became expected. **Virality is a lottery. Consistency is a compounding investment.** A sustainable cadence you can actually keep is infinitely more valuable than an ambitious one you abandon after six weeks.

TAKEAWAY

Define your minimum viable content commitment — the volume & quality you can honestly sustain even in a bad week. Missing once is fine. Missing habitually breaks the trust you've built before you even know they were paying attention.

LESSON 05

The Medium Is Part of the Message

Most founders default to the formats they're most comfortable with rather than the ones most effective for what they're trying to say. Long-form writing builds authority over time. Short video earns attention fast but is easily forgotten. Podcasts create intimacy and loyalty that other formats rarely match. **Events and roundtables generate high-trust attention no algorithm can replicate.**

TAKEAWAY

Ask where your ideal customers are already paying attention voluntarily, not where they're being targeted. These are their 'Spheres of Influence'. Choose the format that lets you demo your specific edge most credibly.

LESSON 06

Distribution Is at Least Half the Work

The best content nobody sees is just a diary entry. Most founders spend 90% of their effort on creation and 10% on distribution. **It should be closer to 50/50.** Distribution means building genuine relationships with people who have existing audiences, understanding which platforms have algorithmic tailwinds right now, and repurposing intentionally.

TAKEAWAY

Map your channels and ask honestly: which are growing, which are shrinking? Then identify 2–3 people with audiences you'd love to reach — and think about how you can genuinely contribute to their work, not just pitch yours.

ASK YOURSELF

What's one thing I've been putting off for your brand because it felt too risky, too personal, or too time-consuming? And what would it mean for my business if I actually did it?

QUICK REFERENCE

Quick Reference

The TRUTH Checklist

Run every story through this before publishing.

- T Topical — Connected to now?
- R Relevant — Written for them?
- U Unusual — Something surprising?
- T Trouble — A problem at centre?
- H Human(ity) — Real people, real stakes?

8 Behavioural Science Principles

- Social Proof — Show specific numbers & named logos.

● Default Effect — Make the right action the path of least resistance.

● Loss Aversion — Frame around what they're losing now.

● Cognitive Fluency — Clarity signals competence. Complexity signals risk.

● Authority Bias — Third-party validation shortcuts scepticism.

● Anchoring — The first number shapes every subsequent judgement.

● Reciprocity — Give value genuinely before asking.

● Peak-End Rule — Obsess over onboarding & renewal moments.

The Six Lessons

- 01 Relevance beats reach

Be unmissable to the right few rather than invisible to the many.
- 02 Your voice is your moat

Founder content with real conviction is powerful ... and unreplicable.
- 03 Structure is learnable

Tension → Insight → Implication. 'Most people think X, but I've come to believe Y, which means Z.'
- 04 Consistency compounds

A sustainable cadence always beats an ambitious one you can't keep.
- 05 Match format to purpose

Choose your medium based on what earns your audience's trust, not what's fashionable.
- 06 Distribute as hard as you create

Spend at least half your effort getting content to the right people.

THE MASTER FORMULA

"Most people think X, but I've come to believe Y, which means Z."

Ready to put this into practice?

smpl Co works with founders and scale-up leaders to build brands, craft stories, and win attention that converts.

If today's roundtable sparked something, let's talk.

BOOK A CONVERSATION → [SMPL.NO](https://smpl.no)